

Kannada, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/kannada/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Kannada volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Kannada letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Kannada simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Kannada is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit. Its own personality shows in one contrast, drawn again and again in these pages: where its oldest sister **Tamil** guards its native word-stock, Kannada borrowed *freely* from Sanskrit. So “hello” is the Sanskrit ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (*namaskāra*) — yet “no” and “okay” are the native Dravidian ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) and ಸರಿ (*sari*), shared almost unchanged with Tamil. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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The Kannada script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ಕ = ka, ಮ = ma, ರ = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ಕಾ = k̄ā, ಕಿ = ki, ಕೀ = k̄ī, ಕು = ku, ಕೂ = k̄ū, ಕೆ = ke, ಕೇ = k̄ē, ಕೊ = ko, ಕೋ = k̄ō, ಕೌ = kau.
3. **A *virama* strips the built-in vowel, and the bare consonant *stacks under the next* as a conjunct (*ottakṣara*):** ನೆ + ಕೆ → ನ್ಕೆ (ska), ನೆ + ಯೆ → ನ್ಯೆ (nya), ಲ + ಲ → ಳ (lla). This stacking is a signature of the Kannada–Telugu scripts.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

ಅ a · ಆ ā · ಇ i · ಈ ī · ಉ u · ಊ ū · ಎ e · ಏ ē · ಐ ai · ಒ o · ಓ ō · ಔ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration is written.** ಕೆ k / ಖ kh, ದೆ d / ಧ dh — the “h” is a real puff. (Unlike Tamil, Kannada keeps separate letters for the Sanskrit aspirates and voiced stops, because it borrowed so many Sanskrit words.)
- **Round forms.** Kannada letters are rounded and looping — developed for writing on palm-leaf, where straight strokes would split the leaf. Telugu, its closest script-sister, shares the look.

Kannada in the Dravidian family

Kannada is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages (with Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam) — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one (English, Latin, Sanskrit). It shares the grammar and much native vocabulary with its sisters, but — like Telugu, and unlike Tamil — it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Kannada words are home-grown (*haudu*, *illa*, *sari*) and which came from Sanskrit (*namaskāra*, *dhanyavāda*).

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Kannada greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Kannada script and how Kannada sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/KA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (namaskāra) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Kannada reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ನ na, ಮ ma, ರ ra. A **vowel sign** changes that vowel: ಕ ka + the long-“ā” sign → ಕಾ kā. And a vowel-less consonant **stacks under** the next as a conjunct (*ottakṣara*): ಸ loses its vowel and tucks under ka → ಸ್ಕ “ska.” Read ನ·ಮ·ಸ್·ಕಾ·ರ → namaskāra.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ (namaskāra) is **not** native Kannada — it is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow, homage”) + *kāra* (“a making,” from the root *kr*, “to do”) = “the making of a bow.” The very same word as Hindi *namaskār*. Where its sister Tamil kept a home-grown greeting (*vaṇakkam*), Kannada borrowed freely from Sanskrit — the theme of this whole book.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Kannada	ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ <i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Tamil alone kept its own word; the rest lean on the Sanskrit *namas-*.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello and goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

1.2 ಧನ್ಯವಾದ (*dhanyavāda*) — “thank you,” an utterance of “worthy”

The letters in this word

New: ಧ *dha* (an **aspirated** *d* — a puff of breath), and the conjunct ನ್ಯ (*na* stacked with *ya* → “*nya*”). ವಾ is *vā*. Read ಧನ್ಯವಾದ → *dhanyavāda*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಧನ್ಯವಾದ (*dhanyavāda*) is **Sanskrit**: *dhanya* (“worthy, blessed,” from *dhana*, “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a saying,” root *vad*, “to speak”) = “an utterance of ‘[you are] worthy.’” The same word as Hindi *dhanyavād* and Telugu *dhanyavādamulu*.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Kannada	ಧನ್ಯವಾದ <i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit — same word
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i>	Sanskrit — same word
Tamil	<i>nanri</i>	native (“goodness”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	native — Tamil’s cousin

A stark split: Kannada, Telugu, Hindi take the Sanskrit word; Tamil and Malayalam keep native *nanri* / *nandi*.

1.3 ಹೌದು (*haudu*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ಹೌ is *hau* (ಹ *ha* with the “au” vowel sign hugging it); ದು is *du* (ದ *da* with the “u” sign beneath). Read ಹೌದು → *haudu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೌದು (*haudu*) is the everyday “yes / that’s so” — a genuinely **native** Kannada word, after two Sanskrit loans.

Grammar Lens

Like its sister Tamil, Kannada often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *bandiddīyā?* (“have you come?”), a natural yes is *bandiddēne* (“I have come”). Bank *haudu* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb — a habit shared across the Dravidian family.

1.4 ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) — “no,” a word Tamil shares almost exactly

The letters in this word

ಇ is the **independent vowel** “i” (word-initial, so a full letter). ಲ್ಲ is “lla” — ಲ *la* vowel-stripped and stacked under another *la*, a held “ll.” Read ಇಲ್ಲ → *illa*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) is built on the old Dravidian root *il*, “not-being” — so, like Tamil *illai*, it really means “[**it**] **is not**, [**there**] **is not**,” serving as the everyday “no.” Its positive twin is ಇದೆ (*ide*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Dravidian negates by *being*. Where English inserts *not*, Kannada — exactly like Tamil — swaps in the negative verb of existence: *pustaka ide* (“there *is* a book”) → *pustaka illa* (“there *is not* a book”). A shared inheritance: Tamil *illai*, Kannada *illa*, Malayalam *illa* — one family, one way to say a thing is not.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Kannada	ಇಲ್ಲ <i>illa</i>	native (root <i>il</i>)
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Malayalam	<i>illa</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i>	native, a different root
Hindi	<i>nahīnī</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

1.5 ಸರಿ (*sari*) — “okay,” shared whole with Tamil**The letters in this word**

ಸ is *sa*; ರಿ is *ri* (ರ *ra* with the “i” sign). No conjunct here — two clean, round syllables. Read ಸರಿ → *sari*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಸರಿ (*sari*) is native Dravidian for “correct, even, right,” and so “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Kannada. It is the *same word* as Tamil *sari* — identical in sound and meaning, only the script differs; doubled, *sari sari* means “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One shared word, two scripts. *sari* is identical in Kannada and Tamil in sound and meaning — only the letters differ (Kannada writes it ಸರಿ, Tamil in its own script). Watching a shared word change its clothes but not its sound is the fastest way to feel how close these languages are — the pattern-matching that carries you across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam.

1.6 Recap, and how Kannada says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
ನಮಸ್ಕಾರ	<i>namaskāra</i>	hello	Sanskrit
ಧನ್ಯವಾದ	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	thank you	Sanskrit
ಹೌದು	<i>haudu</i>	yes	native
ಇಲ್ಲ	<i>illa</i>	no / isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ಸರಿ	<i>sari</i>	okay	native (= Tamil <i>sari</i>)

The pattern is already visible: the two greeting/politeness words are Sanskrit loans; the three everyday grammar words are native Dravidian, two of them shared almost unchanged with Tamil.

Why it’s said this way

The same “go and come back” as Tamil. Kannada, too, avoids a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*hōgi*

baruttēne), “having gone, I [will] come [back],” and the reply is ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ (*hōgi banni*), “go, and come back.” The very worldview you met in Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn*: never simply depart — promise a return.

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *nanna hesaru...* (“my name...”) — and Kannada’s *nānu* / *nāvu* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಅರುಣ್. (nanna hesaru Arun — “My name is Arun.”)
ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? (nimma hesaru ēnu — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/KA-C02-*.md.*

2.1 ಹೆಸರು (*hesaru*) — “name,” and the $p \rightarrow h$ shift

The letters in this word

ಹ (*ha*) + ೆ (the *e*-sign) → ಹೆ (*he*); ಸ (*sa*); ರು (*ru*). Read ಹೆ·ಸ·ರು → *hesaru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೆಸರು (*hesaru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *pesar — and it hides a famous Kannada sound-law: an old initial *p* became *h*. So *pesar → *hesar → *hesaru*. That makes it a *cousin* of Tamil *peyar* (same root; Tamil kept the *p*, Kannada softened it to *h*) — and, like *peyar*, *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). The Dravidian south kept its own word for “name.”

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Kannada	ಹೆಸರು <i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian *pesar (p→h)
Tamil	<i>peyar</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root (kept <i>p</i>)
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

The $p \rightarrow h$ shift is why *hesaru* looks unlike its sisters — but it is the same word.

2.2 ನನ್ನ (*nanna*) — “my”

The letters in this word

ನ (*na*) + the conjunct ನ್ನ (*nn*) → *nanna* — a doubled, held *nn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನನ್ನ (*nanna*, “my”) is the possessive of ನಾನು (*nānu*, “I”) — native Dravidian, on the pronoun stem *nān, the same one behind Tamil *nān* / *en*. It has no Indo-European cousin: the Dravidian “I/my” is a different word from the European *I/my*.

2.3 ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ... (*nanna hesaru ...*) — “my name is...”

ನನ್ನ (my) + ಹೆಸರು (name) + name = **nanna hesaru ...** *Nanna hesaru Arun.*
= “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is.” As in Tamil, notice there is *no* verb: Kannada sets “my name” beside “Arun” and lets the “is” be understood — the **zero copula** of the Dravidian family. *Nanna hesaru Arun* = literally “my name Arun.”

2.4 ನೀನು / ನೀವು (*nīnu* / *nīvu*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

ನೀ (*nī*) + ನು (*nu*) → *nīnu*; ನೀ + ವು (*vu*) → *nīvu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನೀನು (*nīnu*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian *nīn — the same native root as Tamil *nī*. ನೀವು (*nīvu*) is the respectful/plural “you.”

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, once more. *nīnu* (familiar) vs. *nīvu* (respectful, and literally plural) — the same politeness-by-plural as Tamil *nīṅgal* and French *vous*. For a first meeting, *nīvu*.

2.5 ಏನು (*ēnu*) — “what”

The letters in this word

ಏ (independent long ē, word-initial) + ನು (*nu*) → *ēnu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಏನು (*ēnu*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem *yā- / *e- — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *eṇṇa*, heading Kannada’s question family: *ēnu* (what), *yāru* (who), *elli* (where), *yāke* (why).

2.6 ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? (*nimma hesaru ēnu*) — “what’s your name?”

ನಿಮ್ಮ (*nimma*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīvu* (“you,” respectful). So ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no “is.”* Three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Nanna hesaru Arun*. The familiar “your” is *ninna* (from *nīnu*): *ninna hesaru ēnu*?

2.7 ಸಂತೋಷ (santōṣa) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is ನಿಮ್ಮನ್ನು ಭೇಟಿಯಾಗಿ ಸಂತೋಷ (nimmannu bhēṭiyāgi santōṣa) — “**having met you, joy.**” But note the key word: ಸಂತೋಷ (santōṣa, “joy, contentment”) is **Sanskrit** (*sam-* “fully” + *toṣa* “satisfaction”), not native. Where Tamil reaches for its home-grown *magilcci*, Kannada — true to form — uses a Sanskrit word even for “pleased.” The same split you saw over “hello” and “thanks” runs right through the introductions.

2.8 The whole exchange

Kannada		English
ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಮೀರಾ.	<i>nanna hesaru Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
ನಿಮ್ಮ ಹೆಸರು ಏನು?	<i>nimma hesaru ēnu</i>	What’s your name?
ನನ್ನ ಹೆಸರು ಅರುಣ್.	<i>nanna hesaru Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
ಸಂತೋಷ.	<i>santōṣa</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *hesaru* (Dravidian *pesar, p→h; *not name*), *nanna* (from *nānu*, “I”), *ēnu* (Dravidian question-stem) — and *santōṣa*, a Sanskrit loan for “pleased,” the family thread again. The Kannada habit to keep: the **zero copula** (no “is”). Next chapter: *hēgiddīra*? (“how are you?”) and answering with *chennāgiddēne* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — carried by the Dravidian verb “to be”:

ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? (nīvu hēgiddīrā — “How are you?”)
ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ, ಧನ್ಯವಾದ. (nānu cennāgiddēne, dhanyavāda — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/KA-C03-.md.*

3.1 ಹೇಗೆ (hēge) — “how,” another of the ē- questions

The letters in this word

ಹೇ (hē) + ಗೆ (ge) → ಹೇಗೆ (hēge).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೇಗೆ (hēge, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base ē-/yā- from ēnu. Kannada gathers its questions here: ēnu (what), hēge (how), yāru (who), elli (where), yāvāga (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* and Telugu’s *elā* — a family older than the Sanskrit words Kannada otherwise borrows so readily.

3.2 ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ? — “how are you?”

The new word is ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ (hēgiddīrā): hēge (“how”) fused with the verb ಇರು (iru, “to be, exist, stay”) + the respectful-you ending. So ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ?

is “you how are?”, the verb last, as in every Kannada sentence. The verb *iru* is the very same native Dravidian “to be” that Tamil uses — and (Chapter 5) the verb for “I live.”

Grammar Lens

The verb carries “you.” The ending already means “you (respectful),” so *nīvu* can be dropped. To a friend: ನೀನು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀಯಾ? (*nīnu hēgiddīyā?*). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

3.3 ನಾನು (*nānu*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ನಾ (*nā*) + ನು (*nu*) → ನಾನು (*nānu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಾನು (*nānu*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian *yāṇ / *nāṇ — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *maiṃ*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the ನನ್ನ (*nanna*, “my”) you met in Chapter 2. Kannada borrows Sanskrit freely for higher vocabulary, but its bedrock pronouns stayed Dravidian.

3.4 ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ (*cennāgi*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ಚೆ (*ce* — the letter ಚ is “ch as in *cheese*”) + ನ್ನಾ (*nnā*) + ಗಿ (*gi*) → ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿ (*cennāgi*, “well, nicely”) is native Dravidian, from ಚೆನ್ನು (*cennu*, “good, beautiful”) + the adverb-maker *-āgi* (“in a ... way”) — so it means, at heart, “in a beautiful way.” The root *cennu* is pure Kannada, no Sanskrit or European cousin.

Fuse it with *iru*: ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ (*nānu cennāgiddēne*) — “I am well.”

3.5 ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ (*paravāgilla*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ means “it does not matter / there is no harm” — *paravā* (“harm”) + ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*, “is-not”), the Chapter-1 negative. It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*) is Kannada’s “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across **Kannada, Tamil, and Malayalam** — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu* (so Telugu’s “no problem” is *paravāledu*, Kannada’s *paravāgilla*).

Grammar Lens

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *duḍḍu illa* (“there’s no money”). Hold *iru* / *illa* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Kannada	English
ನೀವು ಹೇಗಿದ್ದೀರಾ?	How are you?
ನಾನು ಚೆನ್ನಾಗಿದ್ದೇನೆ, ಧನ್ಯವಾದ.	I’m well, thank you.
ಪರವಾಗಿಲ್ಲ.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *hēge* (the native *ē*- questions), *nānu* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *cennāgi* (“beautifully”), and the *iru* / *illa* pair — “is” and “is-not,” the *illa* shared with Tamil and Malayalam. Next chapter: the farewells — and Kannada, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Kannada, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ. (*hōgi baruttēne* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/KA-CO4-.md.*

4.1 ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*) — “go,” and ಬಾ (come)

The letters in this word

ಹೋ (*hō*) + ಗು (*gu*) → ಹೋಗು. Its partner ಬಾ (*bā*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*, “to go”) and ಬಾ (*bā*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs. As commands they are whole words: *hōgu!* (“go!”), *bā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Kannada’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*hōgi baruttēne*) — “I’ll go and come back”

ಹೋಗಿ (*hōgi*, “having gone”) + ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ (*baruttēne*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Kannada speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ (*hōgi banni*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

4.3 ನಾಳೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ (*nāḷe sigōṇa*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

ನಾಳೆ (*nāḷe*): ನಾ (*nā*) + ಳೆ (*ḷe*, retroflex ಳ *ḷ*). ಸಿಗೋಣ (*sigōṇa*) = *sigu* (“meet”) + *-ōṇa* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ನಾಳೆ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native, from *nāl* (“day”) — the same root as Tamil’s *nāḷai*. ಸಿಗು (*sigu*, “to meet, be found”) gives *sigōṇa* (“let’s meet”) — “tomorrow, let’s meet.” The *-ōṇa* ending is Kannada’s warm “let’s ...”: *hōgōṇa* (“let’s go”).

4.4 ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ (*matte sigōṇa*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ = ಮತ್ತೆ (*matte*, “again”) + *sigōṇa* (“let’s meet”). Both are native Dravidian: *matte* (“again”) and *sigu* (“to meet”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi*, Kannada keeps the native *sigu* — the same phrase, from home-grown stock.

4.5 The farewells

Kannada	English
ಹೋಗಿ ಬರುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
ಹೋಗಿ ಬನ್ನಿ.	Go and come back. (the reply)
ನಾಳೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ.	See you tomorrow.
ಮತ್ತೆ ಸಿಗೋಣ.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *hōgu/bā* (go/come), *nāle* (“tomorrow” ← *nāl* “day,” shared with Tamil), and *sigu* (“meet,” native — where Tamil borrowed *sandi*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nānu kannada mātanāḍuttēne* — and Kannada’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Kannada’s sentences begin to move:

ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ. (*nānu kannaḍa mātanaḍuttēne* — “I speak Kannada.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/KA-C05-.md.*

5.1 ಮಾತನಾಡು (*mātanaḍu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ಮಾ (*mā*) + ತ (*ta*) + ನಾ (*nā*) + ಡು (*ḍu*) → ಮಾತನಾಡು.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಾತನಾಡು (*mātanaḍu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian, built on ಮಾತು (*mātu*, “word, speech”). To say “I speak,” Kannada stacks two endings on the stem — tense then person:

mātanaḍ- + *-utt-* (present) + *-ēne* (“I”) → ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ
(*mātanaḍuttēne*), “I speak.”

The *-ēne* ending is “I,” so *nānu* is rarely needed: *mātanaḍuttāne* (he), *mātanaḍuttāle* (she), *mātanaḍuttāre* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Kannada verb is built this way. And, like Tamil and Telugu, Kannada marks **no gender in the first person**: *mātanāḍuttēne* is the same for a man or a woman.

5.2 ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ — “I speak Kannada”

ನಾನು (I) + ಕನ್ನಡ (*kannada*, the object) + ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ (speak) — “I Kannada speak,” verb last. The name ಕನ್ನಡ (*kannada*) is native, often linked to *kar-nāḍu* (“the high/black land,” whence *Karnataka*). Kannada has a literature over a thousand years old and a store of classical honours — a classical tongue of some fifty million speakers.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Mātanāḍuttēne* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Kannada, like Tamil and Telugu, marks no gender in the first or second person (only the third: *-āne* he, *-āle* she).

5.3 ಇರು (*iru*) — “to be, to stay, to live”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಇರು (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay, live”) is native Dravidian — the very same *iru* Tamil uses, and the verb behind Chapter 3’s *hēgiddirā* (“how are you”) and *cennāgiddēne* (“I’m well”). It also means “to reside”: ನಾನು ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ ಇದ್ದೇನೆ (*nānu Beṅgaḷūrinalli iddēne*, “I live in Bangalore”). One verb covers “be,” “stay,” and “live.”

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ (*Beṅgaḷūrinalli*) = *Beṅgaḷūru* + *-alli* (“in”), glued to the *end* of the noun. Kannada uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes): “Bangalore-in I am,” the verb last.

5.4 ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡು (*kelasa māḍu*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಮಾಡು (*māḍu*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Kannada — like Hindi with *karnā*, Tamil with *sey*, and Telugu with *cēyu* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡು (*kelasa māḍu*, “work-do” = “to work”), *aḍuge māḍu* (“to cook”), *sahāya māḍu* (“to help,” with a **Sanskrit** noun on the **native** *māḍu*). So “I work” is ನಾನು ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ (*nānu kelasa māḍuttēne*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + ಮಾಡು = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*,” Tamil’s “noun + *sey*,” and Telugu’s “noun + *cēyu*.” Four languages, two from an unrelated family, all landed on the same trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Kannada	English
ನಾನು ಕನ್ನಡ ಮಾತನಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I speak Kannada.
ನಾನು ಬೆಂಗಳೂರಿನಲ್ಲಿ ಇದ್ದೇನೆ.	I live in Bangalore.
ನಾನು ಕೆಲಸ ಮಾಡುತ್ತೇನೆ.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *mā-tanāḍu* (speak ← *mātu* “word”), *iru* (be/stay/live, with *-alli* “in” on the noun’s end), and *māḍu* (do → *kelasa māḍu* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*). From here, Kannada’s sentences only grow.